



Against all odds: With ten straight defeats leading up to the World Cup, very few would have bet on New Zealand. AP

New Zealand's 'grandmas' finally bring home T20 crown

Their fairytale journey capped off a remarkable tournament, **sparking hopes** for increased participation from Associate teams in future editions.

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"This is a love story." Remember that iconic frame from Phoebe Waller-Bridge's show, *Fleabag*? If there were a documentary being made on New Zealand's World Cup campaign, it would — and perhaps should — begin with this frame.

The White Ferns have not been the easiest team to support over the past couple of years. They are grade-A characters who can sometimes collapse and cede advantage to the opposition. With ten straight defeats leading up to the World Cup (albeit mostly against stronger teams like England, Australia, and Pakistan), very few would have bet on this side.

To then see this side ascend the podium was a lesson in the sheer power of perseverance.

Belief, however, can only take you so far. Look at South Africa. There has been a seismic shift in how the Proteas approach their cricket. In Laura Wolvaardt (**right**), they have a captain who is accomplished and data-driven, constantly seeking solutions.

Dillon du Preez, Baakier Abrahams, and Paul Adams have nurtured the team into a side that is not scared to fall and pick itself up, working not just on skills and technique, but also on composure and self-compassion.

But that's the nature of the beast. You can desire something with all your heart, but it takes something otherworldly to achieve what the Kiwis did. "It's 5 am in the morning back in New Zealand," said skipper Sophie Devine, with the trophy glistening between her and deputy